BIHAR/ OPPOSITION

A Tense Alliance

By Amitabh Srivastava

A pointed remark made by Congress general secretary Sachin Pilot in Patna on April 11 was enough for Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav to reach out to his key ally's top leadership. Pilot had said that the chief ministerial candidate of the RJD-Congress alliance in Bihar would be decided only after the election later this year. Widely seen as a message to the RJD not to take the Congress for granted, the statement appeared to signal a shift in tone.

By April 15, Tejashwi was in New Delhi, meeting Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi. Behind closed doors, he is learnt to have revisited the bitter memory of the 2020 election, where the alliance missed power by just 12 seats. The RJD had emerged as the single largest party, winning 75 of the 144 seats it contested; the Congress, however, won just 19 out of 70, dragging the coalition short of a majority. Even the Left had done its bit, winning 16 out of 29.

As a concession, on April 17–just two days after the New Delhi meeting–Tejashwi was named the head of the INDIA bloc's coordination committee, responsible for seat-sharing and other poll strategies in Bihar. It signalled that the Congress is not looking to rock the boat–yet.

Meanwhile, the Grand Old Party is allowing itself a spot of bullishness: it has embarked on a spirited revival in Bihar after years of dormancy. Rahul Gandhi has already visited the state thrice this year, aligning himself with pro-backward and Dalit causes, including joining Kanhaiya Kumar's 'Palayan Roko, Naukri Do' (stop migration, give jobs) march in Begusarai. Insiders say the RJD leadership is not entirely nonchalant about Kanhaiya's attempt to garner popular appeal.

The Congress's leadership shuffle speaks volumes too. In February, Rahul favourite Krishna Allavaru, a bright young spark with an INSEAD degree, was made the AICC state in-charge, signalling a clear break. A month later, Dalit leader Rajesh Kumar–from the numerically significant Ravidas community–replaced forward-caste veteran Akhilesh Prasad Singh as the Bihar unit chief. Clearly, the Congress is keen to reclaim space in a state it once dominated, and step out of its partner's shadow.

It won't be just a matter of turning up with good intentions, though. The RJD has to give right of way. How generous will it be? Well, Tejashwi's hopes of securing power, flowing from incumbency fatigue after two decades of Nitish Kumar, also stand buoyed by a potential Muslim consolidation as a result of Waqf Bill amendments. In this climate, the RJD may be less willing to risk indulging a Congress experiment at resurgence.

But the Congress looks determined. After some 35 years in the boondocks, the 2024 Lok Sabha election gave it a glimmer of respectability–the Congress won three of the nine seats it contested, while the RJD won just four of 23. Not only that, Rahul's second cross-country yatra, which passed through Bihar, also pretty much set the narrative with its caste-plus-livelihood focus. The party, expecting that street cred to bear fruit, appears unwilling to settle for crumbs in the upcoming assembly election.

But despite the new energy, the Congress faces structural chal-



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SHOW OF HANDS Rahul Gandhi joins Kanhaiya Kumar's 'Palayan Roko, Naukri Do' march in Begusarai, Apr. 7

CONGRESS HAS EMBARKED ON A SPIRITED REVIVAL IN BIHAR WITH RAHUL GANDHI ALREADY VISITING THE STATE THRICE THIS YEAR